

AP



IN PEACE: Pal with former leader of opposition Fazlur Rehman

cure communication. Officials maintain that in a sensitive diplomatic station like Islamabad, it seems that standard security procedures, like keeping the laptop in a secure place, were not followed, but the fact that the Pakistani intelligence agency managed to mount a daring operation during Emergency, proves that it had the sanction of the top brass of the ISI which functions under the direct control of Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf.

Tension has been simmering for a while and close on the heels of the break-in New Delhi also lodged another protest with Islamabad. This time the accusation was that Radio Pakistan had increased its anti-India propaganda and its Lahore station was airing a programme *Punjabi Durbar* which is exhorting the Sikhs to revive their demand for Khalistan. "All this is part of a well orchestrated strategy by the ISI to foment communal trouble in India and intelligence reports suggest that Sikh militants are being told to revive the Khalistan issue," remarked a South Block source.

Sample a recent broadcast on *Punjabi Durbar*: "The Indian Government has failed to provide justice and job opportunities leading to the mushrooming of fraud deras in Punjab... a number of deras have been set up in Punjab to misguide the people and interfere in the religions of certain communities. Baba Ram Rahim

TERROR FACTORY

■ Pakistani intelligence agency is suspected of stealing the Indian **envoy's** laptop and a briefcase containing sensitive information

■ Tension is brewing following continued broadcast of inflammatory, anti-India statements on Radio Pakistan to foment trouble in Punjab by raking up the Khalistan issue

■ Jehadi groups have been trained to target key political leaders in India like L.K. Advani and Rahul Gandhi

■ Despite Interpol alerts, IC-814 hijackers and 40 other fugitives remain sheltered in Pakistan

Singh, of religious sect Sacha Sauda has been sponsored by official Indian agencies to misguide people." This was aired shortly before a bomb blast targeted the Baba's convoy in February.

Another programme on Lahore I station, the official broadcaster of Pakistan, said: "Brahmin-dominated Hindu imperialistic powers at Delhi have launched a campaign to weaken Sikhism and its culture in Punjab. There is a conspiracy under which Sikh youths are encouraged to leave the religion and take to intoxicants."

Punjabi Durbar, on another occasion said, "The Sikh Panth has to take its own care and there is a dire need of

creating Khalistan where the religion and culture of Sikhs may flourish." The aim of these radio programmes is clearly to foment communal tension and exhort Punjabis to revive the Khalistan movement. New Delhi has lodged a protest with the Pakistani foreign office, which has, in turn, accused the Indian agencies of resorting to similar tactics in Pakistani provinces of Sindh and Baluchistan.

The long list of complaints does not end here as fresh intelligence reports show that ISI continues to mount cross-border terrorism against India through its modules in Bangladesh and Nepal. Recent reports suggest that as part of its new strategy, it has asked militants to target key Indian leaders like L.K. Advani, and the recent Jem plot to abduct Rahul Gandhi was part of the same strategy. In fact, last week, a Lashkar-e-Toiba operative arrested in Bangalore confessed that he had met one of the hijackers of IC-814 in Pakistan, who had asked him to attack key IT installations in Karnataka.

In fact worried over reports that Islamabad may be re-recruiting militants who have been sent back to Pakistan as part of the prisoners' exchange agreement, and with Pakistan's continued denial of consular access to Indian prisoners, New Delhi is mulling over the option of not sending militants back even after they serve their sentences. "All this seems to be part of a calibrated exercise aimed at inconveniencing India but not infuriating us," says former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan G. Parthasarthy. Even as the new strains of mistrust emerge, the Indian diplomatic machinery looks fatigued and frustrated with little progress on important issues like Kashmir and cross-border terrorism. That also explains why Pal's name was recently discussed as one of the likely candidates for the job of the envoy in Washington, in the middle of his three-year term.

Even in the midst of a fractious and controversial election, serious clashes between the army and militants in its North West Frontier Province and daring terror strikes in Rawalpindi, Islamabad has clearly not lost sight of its stated objective of low intensity warfare against India. ■